

PCB Design Tools

With development taking place at a lightening pace, the task of designing complex boards at a faster pace is becoming the talk of the day. There are various PCB design tools available to help you out. Some of them are included in this month's EFY-CD

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A printed circuit board (PCB) is used to mechanically support and electrically connect electronic components. PCBs are inexpensive and can be highly reliable.

With development taking place at a lightening pace, the task of designing complex boards at a faster pace is becoming the talk of the day. Managing design tasks like annotation of user- and system-defined attributes and assigning special properties on pins help save valuable efforts and reduce the overall development time.

There are various PCB design tools available for the purpose. Some of them are included in this month's EFY-CD.

EAGLE 5.10.0

EAGLE is a powerful graphics editor for designing PC board layouts and schematics. The latest version is 5.10.0

What's Special? It consists of three modules: schematic editor, layout editor and auto-router. Schematic, layout and component editors have identical user interfaces. A unique undo/re-do function, with which any previous state of the design can be reconstructed with a few keystrokes, is just one example of EAGLE's user-friendliness.

Distributor. The software can be purchased online from www.cadsoft.de/cgi-bin/order-us. There is also a freeware version, which can be downloaded from the website.

Home page: www.cadsoftusa.com

Download URL: www.cadsoftusa.com/download.htm

Platform Supported: Linux, Mac, Windows

KiCad

KiCad is an open source EDA software

suite for designing schematics of electronic circuits and PCBs.

What's Special? The suite consists of a project manager, schematic editor, netlist converter, PCB designer and gerber viewer. It captures your schematics, builds parts libraries and lays out PCBs. It runs under Windows and various flavours of Linux, and has been ported to the Mac OS X. We have included the Windows version and the source code in the EFY-CD of this month.

Distributor. Being free and open source, this software can be downloaded from sourceforge.net.

Home page: <http://kicad.sourceforge.net/>

Download URL: <http://kicad.sourceforge.net/wiki/index.php/Download>

Platform Supported: Linux, Windows and experimental on Mac OS X

Printed Circuit Board Layout Tool

PCB is a tool for PCB layout.

What's Special? PCB includes many professional features such as 16 copper layer designs by default, RS-274X (Gerber) output, NC drill output, Centroid (X-Y) data output, postscript and encapsulated postscript output, and auto-router.

Distributor. Being free and open source, this software can be downloaded from sourceforge.net.

Home page: <http://pcb.gpleda.org/index.html>

Download URL: <http://sourceforge.net/projects/pcb/files/>

Platform Supported: Windows and any Unix-like operating system. You need either lesstif or gtk on your system.

DipTrace

DipTrace is an MS Windows based EDA software for creating schematic

diagrams and printed circuit boards.

What's Special? It is a professional but easy-to-use PCB design software with powerful auto-router. It consists of four modules: PCB layout (PCB design with easy-to-use manual routing tools, shape-based auto-router and auto-placer), schematic (schematic capture with multi-level hierarchy and export to PCB Layout, Spice or Netlist), component and pattern editors (which allow you to make new parts and footprints) and standard libraries (which include 100,000+ parts). The latest version is 2.1.

Distributor. Registration for DipTrace is done via Plimus (US & International) and ShareIt (Europe) using secured connection.

Home page: www.diptrace.com

Download URL: www.diptrace.com/download.php

Platforms Supported: Windows NT/2000/XP/Vista/7 and Linux (Wine)

ExpressPCB

ExpressPCB is an easy-to-use PCB software for beginners.

What's Special? This electronics design software consists of two applications, one for drawing schematics and the other for PCB layout. ExpressPCB circuit board layout program allows you to complete your layout in a few simple steps. The same is the case with Express SCH. These both have the same user interface.

Distributor. The designing software is free and can be downloaded from website.

Home page: www.expresspcb.com

Download URL: www.expresspcb.com/expresscb.htm/Download.htm

Platform Supported: Windows

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